LoC from NJ 9842 to the Karakoram Pass (see Map 11.1). Neither does this alignment go northwards nor are there any glaciers emanating from the Karakoram Pass. The issue was flagged with the US government by the ministry of external affairs at the behest of the army. However, there was no response from the Americans for quite some time. Eventually, after a lot of prodding, they replied that the 'papers' stating the reasons for this decision could not be traced! This was conveyed to me by Lieutenant General Hridya Kaul, who was the director general of military operations in the early 1980s. The foreign secretary during this period was Ram Sathe.

The situation was further exacerbated when our army learnt that the Pakistani authorities surreptitiously began to give permission to foreign mountaineering expeditions to climb or trek in the Siachen glacier area, taking full advantage of that cartographic misrepresentation. The Pakistan Army conveniently began to assume that the triangle formed by NJ 9842–Karakoram Pass–Sia Kangri was Pakistani territory, knowing well that it was a falsehood. It is a historical fact that the Saltoro range has been a traditional boundary between the Balti people, who are predominantly Shia Muslims, and the Ladakhis.

We came to know of Pakistan's intentions of setting up its military and civil presence in the Siachen area in 1982–83, even if that was partly for mountaineering or adventure activities. Therefore, the Indian Army sought the government's approval and, in a pre-emptive action, occupied most of the important passes and dominating heights on the Saltoro range during April 1984. This ridge line follows a northward direction from NJ 9842, east of which is de jure Indian territory. The operation was named 'Meghdoot' (divine cloud messenger), and it commenced on 13 April 1984. In this joint heliborne operation, the Indian Army was ably supported by the Air Force. 'Bilafond La and Sia La were the first to be occupied by infantrymen; two soldiers heli-lifted at a time in the Alouettes or their Indian versions, the Cheetahs, the only helicopters which could operate at altitudes above 18,000 feet. This was a stupendous feat that required about fifty sorties, just for the initial